



Waiting for the Android Effect!

It has been around for more than a year, but is Android set to make open source the standard for mobile phone operating systems? We take a closer look.

When it was announced with much fanfare in late 2007, many felt that Android would change the way mobile phones were used, forever. After all, it was part of the Open Handset Alliance that was dedicated to promoting open standards on mobile devices. On board were the likes of Intel, Motorola, HTC, NVIDIA and Qualcomm, who were joined a year later by ASUS and Sony Ericsson. And of course, looming above all these was the company that was the main mover behind Android—search behemoth Google. Most of the Android code has been released under the free and open source Apache licence. And the first Android phone hit the market in 2008. So where does Android stand today?

Immense potential

On the surface, there's no doubting the potential of Android. Although Linux has been used on mobile phones before, most notably by Nokia and Motorola, the devices that featured the OS did not really make headlines, barring the Motorola Ming, to an extent.

The reasons for these were many: the devices offered no discernible price advantage over others (unlike in the PC

scenario, where Linux systems have always enjoyed a significant price edge); there were never enough applications around (again, unlike the PC scenario) and the devices themselves were not the most user-friendly.

Top this off with the fact that most companies tended to 'hide' their Linux phone portfolios and highlight their proprietary or smartphone OS-driven devices, and it was no surprise that Linux had not really taken off in the mobile space, even though it had carved a niche for itself and had proved to be a stable and fast OS. In fact, not too many people know that the much-hyped Moto RAZR 2, in fact, runs on Java Linux!

In short, cell phone operating systems seemed to be dominated by the likes of Symbian, Windows Mobile, Mac OS, BlackBerry and Palm, all of which had their own issues, having imposed restrictions on application development and loaded additional cost to the price of a handset. This is why the arrival of Android was greeted by many as a major breakthrough. It was not as if people had not tried using open source or Linux-driven operating systems on phones before—it was just that never before had so many names allied themselves behind a single OS.